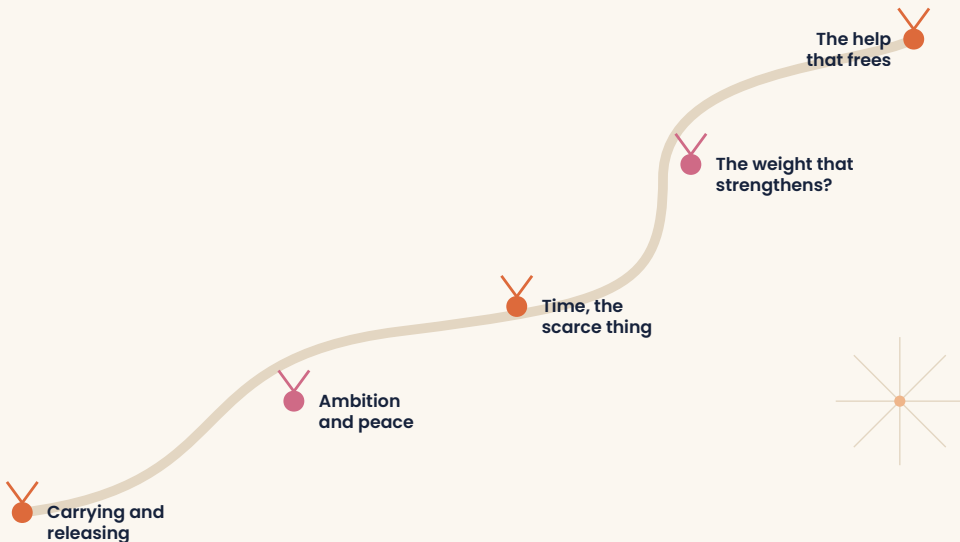


THE BUILDING YEARS · 26–45

How do I carry what I've taken on?

By now most of the big choices are behind you. A job, a place, maybe a person; debts, people who depend on you, a name others lean on. The question stops being *which life?* and quietly becomes *how do I carry this one?*

That fits some lives and not others — people get here late, or twice, or never, and the load sits differently in every pair of hands. Think of the stages as lenses, not a timetable. Five forks lay out the ground, and none of them resolves; each is a tension you'll hold, in your own proportions, for twenty years. The voices in this chapter disagree about every one — which is exactly why they're worth mapping.



The road through the Building Years. Each fork glyph marks a tension mapped in this chapter — **tendencies, never destinies.**

FORK ONE · CARRYING AND RELEASING

Do what is yours. Release the rest.

The heaviest loads of these years — the mortgage, the marriage, the child, the work — are exactly the ones whose outcomes you least control.

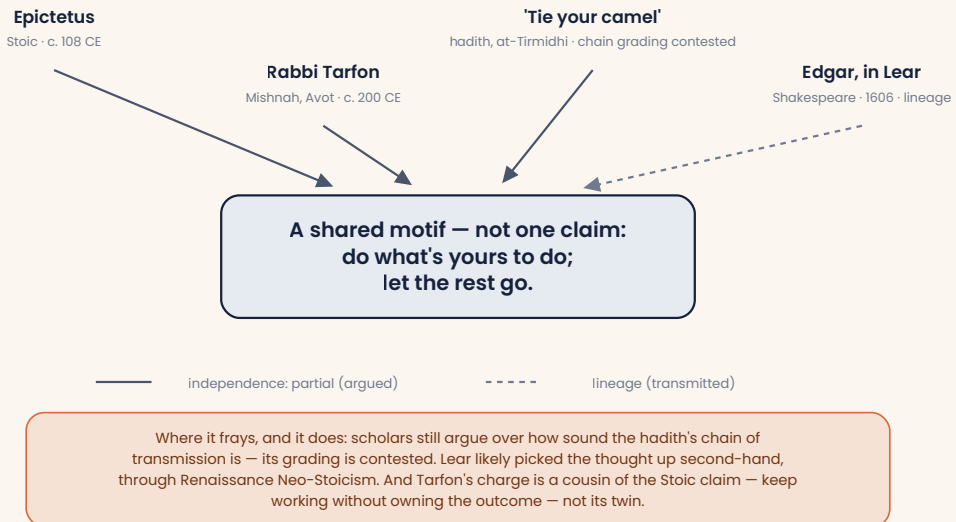
Four people, centuries and continents apart — some plausibly independent, one likely inheriting from the others — land on a similar division of labour: do your part, and let the rest go.

There are things which are within our power, and there are things which are beyond our power. Within our power are opinion, aim, desire, aversion, and, in one word, whatever affairs are our own.

— Epictetus (recorded by Arrian), Enchiridion 1 · trans. Thomas Wentworth Higginson

It is not for thee to finish the work, nor art thou free to desist therefrom

— Rabbi Tarfon, Pirkei Avot (Mishnah) 2:16 · trans. Charles Taylor (Sayings of the Jewish Fathers)



Solid lines: **partial, argued independence**. Dashed: **lineage** — an idea that travelled, which is a different thing from one worked out twice. Convergence is robustness, not proof.

FORK ONE · THE ENGINE UNDERNEATH

The weight is partly a verdict

There's a stranger idea underneath all this dividing-up of the load: that a lot of what crushes us isn't the event itself, but the verdict we hand down on it. Marcus Aurelius, writing to himself:

Take away thy opinion, and then there is taken away the complaint, "I have been harmed." Take away the complaint, "I have been harmed," and the harm is taken away.

— Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 4.7 (cf. 4.3: 'The universe is transformation: life is opinion') · trans. George Long

WISDOM NODE · PRUDENTIAL · CONDITIONAL

A lot of what wrecks a day isn't the thing that happened — it's the story we tell ourselves about it. Change the story and some of the sting goes with it. This is for the ordinary weight you're carrying anyway; it does not cover abuse, material injury, or preventable institutional harm.

Marcus Aurelius

Meditations 4.7 · trans. Long 1862

Drop the opinion of harm, he tells himself, and the complaint falls with it — and with the complaint, the harm.

Epictetus

Enchiridion 1 · trans. Higginson 1865

The older, parent version: the Enchiridion puts opinion first on the short list of things that are actually up to us — before aim, before desire — and Marcus's line supplies the engine for it.

Where it bends · Taken neat, it curdles into gaslighting yourself — some complaints are true. And the neat two-way split is contested, even by people fond of the Stoics: a lot of life isn't cleanly ours or not-ours, but somewhere in between — partly influenced.

text checked to George Long 1862 · 1 source voice behind this claim in the corpus · see where it bends

FORK TWO · AMBITION AND PEACE

The wager and the desperation

Goethe's Faust bets his soul on never being satisfied — the second he asks any moment to stay, he's forfeit. These are the terms of a deal, spoken by a complicated man the story ultimately saves. Read it as a warning shape, not counsel.

Thoreau and Pascal map the ditch on the other side — though their ditches differ. One is giving up, dressed as routine. The other is a whole life spent getting ready to live.

The mass of men lead lives of quiet desperation.

— Henry David Thoreau, Walden 'Economy'

So we never live, but we hope to live; and, as we are always preparing to be happy, it is inevitable we should never be so.

— Blaise Pascal, Pensées Lafuma 47 / Sellier 80 / Brunschvicg 172 · trans. W. F. Trotter

Striving

curdles into Faust's
forfeit — a life spent
arriving, never living

curdles into quiet
desperation — resignation
wearing peace's clothes

Contentment

Your answer is a spot on this line, and it moves as life moves — and the ditch takes more than one shape: driven-ness that never stops, quiet giving-up, and forever getting ready.

A trade-off, drawn in **equal colour** — **neither end is the wiser one here**. Both are good; both go sour if you overdo them. Where you stand is a call you'll **tend** to remake each decade, and this book holds honest voices for every spot on the line.

An older voice turns down both ditches. Faced with the same restlessness, Qoheleth points not to the bet and not to surrender but to the ordinary table: take honest pleasure in your food, your drink, and the work of your hands, in the face of impermanence.

Ask your striving what it's for. Ask your peace what it's avoiding.

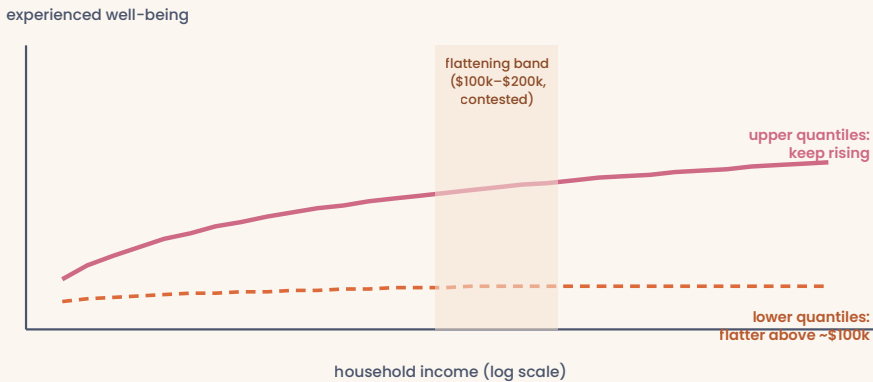
FORK TWO · WHAT THE STUDIES SAY ABOUT MONEY

What money tracks — a contested association

Schopenhauer's side of the fork says happiness rests on what you *are*, not what you have:

We have already seen, in general, that what a man is contributes much more to his happiness than what he has, or how he is regarded by others. [...] The most general survey shows us that the two foes of human happiness are pain and boredom.

— Arthur Schopenhauer, *Aphorisms on the Wisdom of Life* (Parerga und Paralipomena) ch. 2, 'Personality, or What a Man Is' · trans. T. Bailey Saunders



Schematic curves — one model's direction, not plotted data; competing analyses place the flattening differently (below). In the 2023 adversarial collaboration (Killingsworth, Kahneman & Mellers), every slice of measured well-being keeps climbing with income up to about \$100k. Above that, the **lower conditional quantiles** stop climbing much — which is the distribution widening, **not an identified group of unhappy people** hitting a wall. Rohrer & Wenz (2024) warn that reading it as a real subgroup smuggles in causal assumptions the data don't earn; Bennedsen (2024) puts the flattening nearer \$200k. And it's all observational. **Association, not destiny.**

Here's the honest, narrow thing the studies show: *money doesn't matter* is wrong — more money does track with feeling better. What they do **not** test is the bigger claim, Schopenhauer's — that who you *are* matters more than what you *have*. Nobody has weighed character or friendship against a bank balance. Where the climb flattens, and whether money *causes* any of it, both remain open.

FORK THREE · TIME, THE SCARCE THING

Two counsels for the same hour

Seneca sets up the whole fork. The trouble, he says in *On the Shortness of Life*, isn't that we're handed too little time. It's how much of it we let leak away.

In the years when time becomes the scarcest thing you own, two counsels flatly disagree about what to do with the hour in front of you.

Seize the present

In the moment of our talking, envious time has ebb'd away. Seize the present; trust to-morrow e'en as little as you may.

— Horace, *Odes (Carmina)* 1.11.8 · trans. John Conington

SPEAKS TO

the postponer — the one whose real life is always scheduled for later

TRUSTS

today; almost nothing else

CURDLES INTO

a life of small immediacies that never builds anything

TAKE IT WHEN

your plans have quietly become the place you hide

Work as if deathless

To accomplish great things we must live as though we had never to die.

— Luc de Clapiers, marquis de Vauvenargues, *Réflexions et maximes* maxime 142 · trans. Elizabeth Lee

SPEAKS TO

the builder — work that outlasts a season needs a horizon longer than one

TRUSTS

the long arc; compounding; the unfinished

CURDLES INTO

precisely the postponement Seneca condemns

TAKE IT WHEN

the work is worth more than the mood of the week

You can't follow Horace and Vauvenargues in the same breath — it's a real fork about how far ahead to look at any given hour, and this book does not resolve it for you. The **speaks to / take it when** rows are editorial prompts — this book's hypotheses, not sourced findings; choosing is still yours.

Whatever you buy, you pay for it in hours of your one life. Count the hours before you spend, whichever counsel you follow. (After Thoreau.)

FORK FOUR · THE WEIGHT THAT STRENGTHENS?

Does the load make you stronger?

One of the oldest comforts in this whole collection says the load itself teaches you something — and we're printing it *with its asterisk*, because the evidence pulls both ways.

WISDOM NODE · CONTESTED · PRINTED WITH ITS ASTERISK

Suffering can strengthen you, and can teach you — sometimes, for some people. And what people say they grew tends to run ahead of what anyone can actually measure.

Aeschylus' chorus

Agamemnon 176–183 · trans. Smyth

Suffering as the fixed road to understanding — and worth noticing who's singing it: a chorus, inside a cycle of revenge that only a courtroom, at the very end of the trilogy, finally stops.

Nietzsche

Twilight of the Idols · trans. Ludovici

The blow that doesn't kill you can strengthen you — though he later restricted that to the people already healthy enough to turn a blow to advantage.

Where it bends · Neither one arrived at it on their own — Nietzsche had read the tragedians. Lineage, not convergence. Quoted alone, either voice claims more than its own story supports — that is the asterisk.

WHAT THE STUDIES ADD

- In one two-month study that tracked 122 students through a trauma, how much people said they'd grown lined up poorly with the change you could actually measure in them (Frazier 2009). Read it as a measurement caution, not a verdict on any one survivor's story.
- Across 54 studies of different hard events, the most common path wasn't growth and wasn't collapse — it was resilience, staying near your usual self, as each study defined it (about two-thirds of people; Galatzer-Levy, Huang & Bonanno 2018).

texts checked (Smyth · Ludovici) · claim contested — the evidence cuts both ways · print only with this asterisk

FORK FIVE · THE HELP THAT FREES

Raising others without owning them

The Building Years are the raising years.

Two people, eight centuries apart. A shared scriptural background is possible, but nothing on paper links them — and both, in their different ways, turn down the gift that mostly makes the giver feel good. They aim at different targets, but they share the suspicion.

There are eight levels of tzedakah, each one greater than the other. The greatest level, higher than all the rest, is to fortify a fellow Jew and give him a gift, a loan, form with him a partnership, or find work for him, until he is strong enough so that he does not need to ask others [for sustenance].

— Maimonides (Moses ben Maimon), Mishneh Torah, Hilkhoh Mattenot Aniyim 10:7 · trans. Joseph B. Meszler · trans. Joseph B. Meszler, CC BY 4.0, via Sefaria

love in action is a harsh and dreadful thing compared with love in dreams. ... active love is labor and fortitude, and for some people too, perhaps, a complete science.

— Fyodor Dostoevsky, The Brothers Karamazov Book II, ch. 4 'A Lady of Little Faith' (Zosima to Madame Khokhlakova; Garnett spells her 'Hohlakov') · trans. Constance Garnett

Maimonides puts one kind of giving above every warmer-feeling kind: the gift that strengthens — a loan, a partnership, the job that ends the asking. Anonymity marks a separate rung, lower down.

Zosima aims elsewhere: at the giver's staying power — love as work you keep doing when nobody's clapping, as against the quick, admired kind that mostly lives in daydreams.

The two rhyme — both turn down help that mostly flatters the helper — but they're cousins, not one claim, and they test your giving in two different places.

So: two tests for your help. What does it leave the other person able to do — and what does it ask of you when nobody's clapping?

THE BUILDING YEARS · A QUIET CLOSE

The unhistoric years

Most of what these two decades build will never be visible. No map of a life should pretend otherwise — or pretend it matters less for that.

George Eliot ends *Middlemarch* on this sentence — the narrator's last word on Dorothea Brooke, a woman whose large nature never found the large outlet it was built for.

But the effect of her being on those around her was incalculably diffusive: for the growing good of the world is partly dependent on unhistoric acts; and that things are not so ill with you and me as they might have been, is half owing to the number who lived faithfully a hidden life, and rest in unvisited tombs.

— George Eliot, *Middlemarch* Finale (final sentence)

You can read it two ways, and people do. As comfort — the quiet, unremembered life still counted. Or as a quiet protest: look what the world wasted. Eliot leaves both doors open, and so will we; partly because shutting one would be presumptuous, and partly because most of us need both, on different days.

To this book's eye — and that's a judgment, not a finding — it's the truest sentence in the *Building Years*: the work was never required to be finished, and it wasn't put down.